

THE UNIVERSAL HOUSE OF JUSTICE

1988-04-21

To the bahá'ís of the world

1 Ridván 1988

To the bahá'ís of the world

2 dearly loved friends,

3 At this resplendent, festive season, we greet you all in a spirit of renewed
4 hope.

5 A silver lining to the dark picture which has overshadowed most of this
6 century now brightens the horizon. It is discernible in the new tendencies
7 impelling the social processes at work throughout the world, in the evi-
8 47-1. pm, no. 85..47 .1

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49 message from The Universal House of Justice

50 tendencies of an accelerated trend towards peace. In the faith of God, it is the
51 growing strength of the order of Bahá'u'lláh as its banner rises to more
52 stately heights. It is a strength that attracts. The media are giving increasing
53 attention to the Bahá'í world community; authors are acknowledging its
54 existence in a growing number of articles, books and reference works, one
55 of the most highly respected of which recently listed the faith as the most
56 widely spread religion after Christianity. A remarkable display of interest in

57 this community by governments, civil authorities, prominent personalities and
humanitarian organizations is increasingly apparent. Not only are the community's laws and
principles, organization and way of life being investi-

58 gated, but its advice and active help are also being sought for the alleviation
59 of social problems and the carrying out of humanitarian activities.

A thrilling consequence of these favorably conjoined developments is

60 the emergence of a new paradigm of opportunity for further growth and
consolidation of our worldwide community. New prospects for teaching the cause at all
levels of society have unfolded. These are confirmed in the early results flowing from the
new teaching initiatives being fostered in a number

61 of places as more and more national communities witness the beginnings
62 of that entry by troops promised by the beloved master and which Shoghi
63 effendi said would lead on to mass conversion. The immediate possibilities
64 presented by this providential situation compel us to expect that an expan-
65 sion of the community of the most great Name, such as has not yet been
66 experienced, is, indeed, at hand.

The spark which ignited the mounting interest in the cause of

67 bahá'u'lláh was the heroic fortitude and patience of the beloved friends in
68 iran, which moved the bahá'í world community to conduct a persistent,
69 carefully orchestrated program of appeal to the conscience of the world.

This vast undertaking, involving the entire community acting unitedly

through its Administrative order, was accompanied by equally vigorous

70 and visible activities of that community in other spheres, which have been
71 detailed separately. Nonetheless, we are impelled to mention that an impor-
tant outcome of this extensive exertion is our recognition of a new stage in
72 the external affairs of the cause, characterized by a marked maturation of
73 National Spiritual Assemblies in their growing relations with governmental
74 and nongovernmental organizations and with the public in general.

This recognition prompted a meeting in germany last November of na-

75 tional bahá'í external affairs representatives from europe and North Amer-48.3

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50 8ica, together with senior representatives of the offices of the bahá'í inter-
51 national community, intent on effecting greater coordination of their work.

52 This was a preliminary step towards the gathering of more and more Na-

53 tional Spiritual Assemblies into a harmoniously functioning, international network
capable of executing global undertakings in this rapidly expanding field. related to these
developments was the significant achievement of in-

54 ternational recognition accorded the faith through its formal acceptance last
55 october into membership of the Network on conservation and religion of
56 the renowned world wide fund for Nature.

57 At one of the darkest periods in the prolonged oppression of the dearly
58 loved, resolutely steadfast friends in iran, Shoghi effendi was moved to
59 comfort them in a letter of astounding insight. "it is the shedding of the
60 sacred blood of the martyrs in persia" he wrote, "which, in this shining era,
61 this resplendent, this gem-studded bahá'í age, shall change the face of the
62 earth into high heaven and, as revealed in the Tablets, raise up the tabernacle of the
oneness of mankind in the very heart of the world, reveal to men's eyes the reality of the
unity of the human race, establish the most great

63 peace, make of this lower realm a mirror for the Abhá paradise, and establish

64 beyond any doubt before all the peoples of the world the truth of the verse: '... the
day when the earth shall be changed into another earth.'" reflec-

65 tions like these, in adducing such wondrous future consequences from the
66 horrific suffering to which our iranian friends are subjected, illuminate the
67 opportunity and the challenge facing us all at this crucial moment in the
68 fortunes of the cause.

69 The great projects already launched must be pursued to their completion.

70 The Terraces below and above the Shrine of the báb and the Arc on mount

71 carmel must be completed, fulfilling the glorious vision of the efflorescence of god's
holy mountain; the second world congress must be held in the

72 city of the covenant to celebrate the hundredth anniversary of the inaugu-

73 ration of that covenant; the steadily advancing work on the translation and

74 annotation of the kitáb-i-Aqdas, the most holy book, must be brought to

75 publication; the interest shown by the friends in the law of puqúqu'lláh

76 must be cultivated; the pioneers and traveling teachers must go forth; the expenses of
the cause must be met; all objectives of the Six year plan must

77 be achieved.

78 but the paramount purpose of all bahá'í activity is teaching. All that has

79 been done or will be done revolves around this central activity, the “head 48.6

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49 m e S a g e S f r o m T h e u n i v e r S a l h o u S e o f j u S T i c e

50 8corner-stone of the foundation itself,” to which all progress in the cause is

51 due.48-1 The present challenge calls for teaching on a scale and of a quality,

52 a variety, and intensity outstripping all current efforts. The time is now, lest

53 opportunity be lost in the swiftly changing moods of a frenetic world. let it

54 not be imagined that expedience is the essential motive arousing this sense

55 of urgency. There is an overarching reason: it is the pitiful plight of masses of
humanity, suffering and in turmoil, hungering after righteousness, but

56 “bereft of discernment to see god with their own eyes, or hear his melody

with their own ears.”

57 48-2 They must be fed. vision must be restored where

58 hope is lost, confidence built where doubt and confusion are rife. in these

59 and other respects, The Promise of World Peace is designed to open the way.

60 its delivery to national governmental leaders having been virtually com-

61 pleted, its contents must now be conveyed, by all possible means, to peoples

62 everywhere from all walks of life. This is a necessary part of the teaching

63 work in our time and must be pursued with unabated vigor.

64 Teaching is the food of the spirit; it brings life to unawakened souls and

65 raises the new heaven and the new earth; it uplifts the banner of a unified

66 world; it ensures the victory of the covenant and brings those who give

67 their lives to it the supernal happiness of attainment to the good pleasure of their
lord.

every individual believer—man, woman, youth and child—is sum-

68 moned to this field of action; for it is on the initiative, the resolute will of the
individual to teach and to serve, that the success of the entire com-munity depends.
well-grounded in the mighty covenant of bahá’u’lláh,

69 sustained by daily prayer and reading of the holy word, strengthened by a

70 continual striving to obtain a deeper understanding of the divine Teachings,
illuminated by a constant endeavor to relate these Teachings to current issues, nourished by
observance of the laws and principles of his wondrous world

71 order, every individual can attain increasing measures of success in teach-
72 ing. in sum, the ultimate triumph of the cause is assured by that “one thing
73 and only one thing” so poignantly emphasized by Shoghi effendi, namely,
74 “the extent to which our own inner life and private character mirror forth in
75 their manifold aspects the splendor of those eternal principles proclaimed
by bahá’u’lláh.”

76 48-3

77 48-1. w T, p. 10.

78 48-2. bp , p. 310.

79 48-3. bA, p. 66.48.9

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50 85beloved friends—you who are addressed by the best beloved, the blessed

51 beauty, as “the solace of the eye of creation,” as “the soft-flowing waters

52 upon which must depend the very life of all men”48-4—we urge you, with

53 all earnestness from the utter depths of our conviction as to the ripeness

54 of the time, to lay aside your every minor concern and direct your energies

55 to teaching his cause—to proclaiming, expanding and consolidating it.

56 you can approach your task in full confidence that this clear field of prog-

57 ress outstretched before you derives from the operation of that “g od-born

58 force” which “vibrates within the innermost being of all created things” and

59 which, “acting even as a two-edged sword, is, under our very eyes, sunder-ing, on
the one hand, the age-old ties which for centuries have held together the fabric of civilized
society, and is unloosing, on the other, the bonds that

60 still fetter the infant and as yet unemancipated f aith of b ahá’u’lláh.”

61 48-5

have no fear or doubts. The power of the covenant will assist you and

62 invigorate you and remove every obstacle from your path. “h e, verily, will

63 aid everyone that aideth him, and will remember everyone that remembe-

reth h im.”48-6

you have our abiding assurance of ardent and constant prayers for you

64 all.

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[signed: The Universal House of Justice]